

DHOLAKIA FOUNDATION,
Amreli, Gujarat

Key person: **Savjibhai Dholakia,** Founder
Year of inception: **2008**

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Dholakia's first effort was a 22-acre pond created on the Gagadiyo riverbed in his village Dudhala in 2008. 'Amrut Sarovar' was a success**
- **Next project was in 2017—the 120-acre Hari Krishna Sarovar created at a junction between three villages. Caters to needs of 50,000 people**
- **Dholakia has put aside 10% of his wealth for the foundation. It is planning 100 ponds, 75 are ready. Is also planting 10 million trees by 2030**
- **State govt has asked foundation to create similar ponds on cost-sharing basis in other arid areas**

Dholakia to construct similar ponds for their villages. Finally, in 2017, Savjibhai decided to go back and take it up in earnest. The first project was Hari Krishna Sarovar, created at a meeting point between three villages, and spread over 120 acres. The soil dredged out was used to create a garden nearby, which has since become a popular picnic spot for villagers. The three villages, with some 50,000 residents, have now become so self-sufficient that they do not need government water at all.

Buoyed by this success, Dholakia decided to divert 10 per cent of his personal wealth to the foundation to build 100 such ponds, of which 75 are ready. From Chamardi village to Krankach, a span of 52.9 km are now lined with 149 check dams. The land surrounding the river has roads lined by fruit trees on each side.

In Amreli's arid landscape, this region has transformed into a green oasis. The birds have returned and aquatic life is thriving. In the past eight years, water tables have risen to 15 feet (from 600 feet in the past) in some areas. Best of all, farmers now take three harvests a year. "We have infused no new source of water; this is simply from harvested rainwater," says Dholakia, adding that 75 villages currently benefit from the changed ecology.

The state government has now taken note and has requested the Dholakia Foundation to create similar ponds on a cost-sharing basis in the semi-arid river basins in Siddhpur taluka in north Gujarat. ■